Calcutta and any station in Bengal.' Colin Mackenzie agreed, and emphasised the degree to which the Ghilzai saw it as an outright betrayal: 'Sir William reported that the Chiefs "acquiesced in the justice of the reduction"; but on the contrary they considered it a direct break of faith. The whole deficiency amounted only to Rs 40,000, and this attempt at economy was the main cause of the outbreak and all its subsequent horrors.'[51] Mohan Lal was more succinct: 'For the deductions of a few lakhs of rupees, we raised the whole country against us.'[52]

Part of the problem was that by the autumn of 1841 the chiefs and their dependants simply could not afford the cuts. The military reforms had already eaten into their incomes, the real value of which was fast falling due to hyperinflation: the 4,500 troops and 11,500 camp followers who were resident in Kabul had put a huge burden on the poorly integrated Afghan economy and the effect of the sudden flood of silver rupees and letters of credit into the country was a sharp rise in commodity prices: by June 1841, according to Macnaghten, some basic products had risen by 500 per cent.[53x] This was especially so of grain, driving the Afghan poor to the edge of starvation. Mohan Lal realised this, and tried to warn Burnes of the consequences. 'The purchase made by our Commissariat officers of grain raised the price too high and placed it utterly beyond the reach of the population in general,' he wrote. 'Grass for cattle, meat and vegetables, and in short all the necessities of life, rose to a considerable price. The cry of starvation was universal, and there were very many hardly able to procure a piece of bread even by begging in the streets, while everything would have been in abundance but for our purchases.'[54]

To make matters worse, the exact details of the cuts and how to implement them were left by Macnaghten to the tactless and unpopular Nizam al-Daula to work out. Not only did he reduce the allowances in a manner which insulted many of the most loyal followers of Shah Shuja, on 1 September he forced even the most senior to reapply for their military posts and re-swear their oath of allegiance to the Shah. When the nobles all refused to do so, saying this was unprecedented and beneath their honour, 'that it was not the custom of kings to mistrust their servants, and to demand a paper bond of this nature from them', they were all summarily threatened with exile.[55] It was at the next durbar that the first serious opposition showed itself. Mohammad Husain Herati was in the Bala Hisar at the time. 'One day,' he recalled,